

From Slave Labor to Robot Labor: Reviving Greek Scholē in the Age of AI

Executive summary

Ancient Greek elites often treated **manual, necessity-driven labor** as an obstacle to virtue, citizenship, and philosophy—work suited to **slaves, hired laborers, or “banausic” craftsmen**—while the “best life” required **scholē** (leisure) for education, politics, and contemplation. Aristotle states bluntly that “the citizens must not live a mechanic or a mercantile life...for leisure is needed both for the development of virtue and for active participation in politics,” and he connects slavery to a technological thought experiment: if tools could work on their own, “masters [would have] no need of slaves.” ¹

This essay argues for a *modernized revival* of that ideal—**not** by re-endorsing human hierarchy or human bondage (which are morally indefensible today), but by recovering the doctrine’s **teleology**: *necessary production is for the sake of a higher human end*. Aristotle’s slogan—**business for the sake of leisure**—becomes newly actionable when AI systems and robots can shoulder more routine cognitive and physical tasks. ²

Yet contemporary automation can also intensify domination: it may concentrate wealth, conceal new “ghost work,” and externalize exploitation to data workers and extractive supply chains. ³ The core claim defended here is therefore conditional: **AI can realize the ancient aim without violating dignity only if** we build institutions that (a) distribute leisure-capability broadly, (b) prevent a new underclass of human “service” labor, (c) govern AI with rights-preserving standards, and (d) treat leisure as an educated civic practice rather than passive consumption. ⁴

The ancient Greek doctrine of leisure over labor

The view you’re recalling is best captured by the Greek term **scholē** (σχολή), usually translated as *leisure* but carrying the positive sense of **time and freedom for learning, civic participation, and the cultivation of virtue**. Modern English “school” comes through Latin *schola* from Greek *scholē*, preserving that link between education and leisure-time. ⁵ Scholars have emphasized that for Aristotle, *scholē* can function not merely as “time off,” but as a **political end** a city should enable. ⁶

What makes the doctrine morally provocative is its social mechanism: **Greek leisure for some depended on unfree or politically excluded labor by others**. Aristotle explicitly ranks ways of life and ties civic excellence to freedom from degrading or time-consuming work. He insists that in the best regime, citizens should not live as **mechanics, merchants, or even farmers**, because such lives obstruct virtue and politics, and he calls some forms of work “servile” or akin to limited slavery. ⁷ Xenophon, while often praising agriculture as a free man’s pursuit, similarly disparages “base mechanic arts” for ruining bodies and—crucially—**leaving “no leisure” for friendship and the state**. ⁸

Two further conceptual pieces anchor the doctrine:

First, Greek thinkers often distinguish **life aimed at necessity** from life aimed at the **noble (kalon)**. Aristotle says “life as a whole is divided into business and leisure...our actions are aimed some...at things necessary and useful, others at things noble,” and that *war is for the sake of peace* and *business for the sake of leisure*. ⁹

Second, the doctrine is not merely elitist “rest.” Aristotle argues that leisure itself requires **virtue and education**: leisure should not collapse into play, because happiness is an end, and leisure “contains pleasure and happiness and felicity of life.” ⁹ This matters for modern revival: Greek *scholē* is an **active, disciplined** freedom, not mere idleness.

Primary sources: what Plato, Aristotle, and Xenophon actually say

The strongest case that the Greeks conceptualized labor as a means to free contemplation emerges from a **converging trilogy**: Plato’s ideal city, Aristotle’s best regime, and Xenophon’s civic-moral critique of crafts.

Aristotle supplies the most explicit hierarchy of labor, citizenship, and leisure. In *Politics* he writes that the best constitution aims at happiness through virtue; therefore, “the citizens must not live a mechanic or a mercantile life...nor yet must those who are to be citizens...be tillers of the soil,” because “leisure is needed both for the development of virtue and for active participation in politics.” ¹⁰ In the same work he treats slavery as an “instrument” arrangement within household management—going so far as to call the slave a “live article of property”—and then imagines automated tools (self-moving shuttles and harps) that would eliminate the need for slaves. ¹¹ This is not a modern reading imposed on Aristotle; Aristotle himself links **technological automation** to the abolition of slavery’s economic role. ¹²

Plato grounds the idea in political design. In *Republic* Book II, Socrates constructs a “city in speech” where social cooperation begins in mutual need; efficiency and excellence come when each person does **one task suited to their nature**, “each and every one man one occupation...at leisure from other occupations.” ¹³ Later, Plato insists that guardians must be “released from all other crafts” so they can devote themselves to protecting and governing the city. ¹⁴ In Book V, he adds an institutional mechanism: guardians should not own private property but should receive support “from the other citizens for their support,” so they remain true guardians rather than becoming farmers or householders. ¹⁵ Plato thus separates **governing-and-thinking** from **productive labor** via a class structure.

Xenophon provides a civic-ethical argument that anticipates Aristotle’s “leisure for politics” line. In *Oeconomicus*, Socrates says the “base mechanic arts” are disreputable because they physically degrade workers and overseers, and because they consume time so fully that workers have “no leisure to devote to the claims of friendship and the state.” He notes some warlike states allow no citizen to practice such crafts.

⁸ Though Xenophon is not a systematic theorist of the contemplative life, his critique supports a broad Greek belief: **a polity’s freedom depends on protecting citizens’ time from necessity-labor**. ¹⁶

Scholarly interpretations and the standard criticisms

Modern scholarship generally agrees on two points: the Greek leisure ideal is philosophically influential and politically instructive, but historically entangled with **exclusion**.

First, Aristotle's *scholē* is now widely read as a **positive mode of life** requiring material conditions and civic education, not merely "time off." A peer-reviewed treatment in *Polis* emphasizes that Aristotelian leisure is a "way of being" requiring virtues, resources, and education—and asks what, if anything, it can mean for liberal democracy. ¹⁷ Kalimtzis similarly argues that Aristotle advances *scholē* as a political organizing principle, distinct from later Roman/modern "leisure" connotations. ¹⁸

Second, the most powerful criticism is moral: the ancient model secures leisure for citizens by assigning necessary labor to those deemed inferior—slaves, resident foreigners, women, or craftsmen. Aristotle's natural-slavery theory has been sharply criticized in modern philosophy. Nicholas D. Smith notes that Aristotle's attempt to justify "natural slavery" has been judged by many commentators as failing to establish either its morality or its feasibility. ¹⁹ Historians have also stressed that Greek "freedom" and elite culture advanced "hand in hand" with slavery, making the leisure ideal structurally complicit in domination. ²⁰

A second line of critique targets **elitism and political exclusion** even apart from slavery: Aristotle's exclusions of craftsmen and other workers from full citizenship appear difficult to justify even within his own teleological framework, and contemporary scholars explicitly press this "aporia." ²¹

These criticisms are decisive against *literal revival*. But they do not show that the **core teleological claim** is wrong. They show that the Greeks pursued that claim through unjust social forms. The question for AI ethics, then, is whether we can separate:

- the **end**: human flourishing through educated leisure, contemplation, and civic action, ²²
from
- the **means**: human bondage and class exclusion, ²³
and replace those means with non-human labor **without** building a new human underclass.

AI and robotics as Aristotle's "self-moving tools"

Aristotle's automation thought experiment is startlingly modern: if tools could "perform [their] own work when ordered...master-craftsmen would have no need of assistants and masters no need of slaves." ¹² The age of AI and robotics does not fully realize "self-moving shuttles," but it increasingly approximates them in **two domains**: physical production and cognitive/clerical work.

Industrial robotics already constitutes a massive "nonhuman labor force." The International Federation of Robotics reports **4,281,585 industrial robots operating in factories worldwide in 2023** (a 10% increase), with **541,302 installations in 2023** and the majority of new deployments in Asia. ²⁴ These systems automate repetitive, high-precision tasks, shifting some forms of manual labor from humans to machines—though not uniformly across industries.

Generative AI extends automation into "office" tasks. Empirical studies show measurable productivity gains when workers use AI assistants: Brynjolfsson, Li & Raymond's large-scale workplace study finds a roughly **14% productivity increase** for customer support agents after introducing an AI conversational assistant, with larger gains for less experienced workers. ²⁵ Noy & Zhang find that access to ChatGPT can reduce time and improve quality in professional writing tasks, with distributional effects that can reduce inequality in performance. ²⁶

Macro-level exposure estimates reinforce this: OpenAI’s “GPTs are GPTs” analysis suggests a large share of the U.S. workforce has some tasks exposed to LLM capabilities, while an ILO working paper emphasizes that exposure is task-specific and often implies **partial task automation** rather than full occupation automation. ²⁷ A crucial bridge to Aristotle is that “exposed tasks” frequently correspond to the very **time-consuming necessities**—paperwork, scheduling, drafting, routine analysis—that crowd out civic and contemplative life.

But the same literature warns that automation is not automatically emancipatory. Acemoglu & Restrepo’s task-based framework emphasizes that automation displaces some tasks and can reduce labor demand in those tasks, while “new tasks” can reinstate labor demand; the distributional outcome depends on which tasks are automated and who captures the gains. ²⁸ In other words: AI can create leisure, or create unemployment and precarity, depending on institutional design.

Finally, AI systems themselves are socially “made,” and their apparent autonomy can conceal intensive human labor and extractive supply chains. Gray & Suri document how digitally mediated services rely on an “invisible” workforce (“ghost work”). ²⁹ Crawford argues AI is a technology of extraction—from minerals to data to labor—disputing any picture of AI as cleanly “virtual.” ³⁰ Peer-reviewed business ethics work likewise highlights that AI supply chains often rely on poorly regulated crowdwork, raising labor-standard concerns. ³¹ Any attempt to make robots our “slaves” must therefore guard against simply relocating domination to unseen humans.

flowchart TD

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    A[Ancient ideal: scholē as the end of politics] --> B[Problem: leisure
    historically bought by human slavery & exclusion]
    B --> C[Modern rupture: moral equality forbids human bondage]
    C --> D[Technological opening: AI + robotics automate some necessary tasks]
    D --> E{Institutional choice}
    E -->|Concentrated gains| F[Outcome: inequality + hidden labor + domination]
    E -->|Shared gains| G[Outcome: democratized leisure-capability]
    G --> H[Education for leisure: civic, artistic, contemplative practices]
    H --> I[Flourishing: participation + reflection + autonomy]
    F --> J[Safeguards needed: labor standards, rights, redistribution,
    governance]
    J --> E
  
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This diagram operationalizes Aristotle’s own premise—business for leisure—while showing that the critical variable is **governance and distribution**, not raw capability. ³²

A rigorous defense of a modernized scholē doctrine

A defensible revival must be explicit about what it takes from antiquity and what it rejects.

It takes three normative theses. First, the **teleological priority** thesis: necessary production is not the final human aim; rather, humans should organize production so that the ultimate social goal is the free cultivation of virtue, knowledge, and civic life. Aristotle articulates this as business for the sake of leisure and the noble. ³³

Second, the **leisure-as-capability** thesis: leisure is not mere absence of work but a real freedom requiring education and social conditions. Aristotle insists leisure must be used well, not reduced to play, and scholarly interpretations emphasize leisure as a practiced mode of life. ³⁴

Third, the **automation substitution** thesis: in principle, nonhuman tools can replace the labor formerly assigned to slaves. Aristotle himself provides the template via the “self-moving tools” passage. ¹²

It rejects two ancient commitments. First, it rejects the **moral hierarchy of persons** (natural slavery, exclusion of craftsmen); modern equality and dignity norms condemn that structure, and modern scholarship finds Aristotle’s justification unpersuasive. ³⁵ Second, it rejects **political monopoly** of leisure by a ruling class: Plato’s guardianship model becomes valuable not as a class system but as an insight about what intensive governance and truth-seeking require—time, insulation from petty acquisition, and civic trust. ¹⁵

From these premises we can build a modern argument.

If a society has (i) technologies capable of reducing the aggregate burden of necessary labor (AI/robots), ³⁶ and (ii) institutions capable of distributing the gains (economic + temporal) broadly rather than concentrating them, ³⁷ then (iii) it is morally and politically rational to treat the expansion of educated leisure—*scholē*—as a central public goal. The doctrine is no longer “manual labor is for slaves,” but “**servile tasks are for servile systems**”: let *machines do the degrading, dangerous, repetitive work*, while humans are guaranteed the time and resources to pursue the activities that express their dignity.

The key ethical pivot is that **the “slave” is no longer a human being**. Contemporary AI systems are generally treated as tools, not moral persons; Aristotle’s framing of the slave as a “living tool” becomes, ironically, a description better suited to automation than to humanity. ¹¹ A modernized doctrine must nevertheless include a conditional clause: if future AI systems became sentient or capable of suffering, the analogy would break, and using them as “slaves” would become a new form of domination. (This is precisely why modern proposals should avoid designing AI toward sentience and should build governance that can update moral status assessments.)

Equality and justice objections, answered

The most direct objection is that reviving the Greek view repeats elitism: it risks creating a leisure-class while others remain trapped in low-status work. Ancient Greece is the cautionary tale here; scholarship on slavery and political exclusion underlines how freedom can be structurally paired with unfreedom. ³⁸ The answer is that a modern revival must institutionalize **universal access** to leisure-capability as a matter of justice, not privilege. The question becomes not “who deserves leisure?” but “how do we prevent any group from being forced into necessity-labor so others can flourish?”

A second objection is that work can be meaningful, and treating labor as “servile” insults workers and undermines social solidarity. Aristotle’s own rhetoric about “ignoble” lives is vulnerable to this charge. ³⁹ The modernized response is to distinguish **(a)** the value of *chosen, meaningful work* from **(b)** the injustice of *compulsory necessity-work under deprivation*. The revived doctrine targets the second. Indeed, Xenophon’s critique of trades focuses not on pride in craft but on the bodily degradation and civic time-poverty imposed by certain work patterns. ⁸ A society can honor craft while still aiming to automate the tasks that crush bodies and shrink civic freedom.

A third objection is political: even if AI can reduce required labor, why should contemplation be the social aim rather than consumption, entertainment, or growth? Aristotle's reply is that leisure is not arbitrary; it is the condition for virtue and the noble, and "leisure seems itself to contain pleasure and happiness." ⁹ Modern pluralism should soften Aristotle's singular hierarchy, but it need not abandon the idea that **some uses of freedom are higher** because they are autonomy-enhancing: education, art, care, civic participation, spiritual practice, and reflective inquiry.

Safeguards and ethical frameworks for "AI-enabled leisure with dignity"

A dignitarian revival requires safeguards that directly address the modern failure modes of automation:

The first safeguard is **anti-underclass design**: treat all remaining human work that supports AI (data labeling, content moderation, hardware supply chains, maintenance) as dignified labor requiring fair standards. The existence of "ghost work" and critiques of AI's extractive political economy show why this must be explicit. ³ One practical ethical anchor is the UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights ("Protect, Respect and Remedy"), which articulate corporate responsibility to respect rights across value chains. ⁴⁰

The second safeguard is **rights-preserving AI governance**: align AI deployment with established public frameworks emphasizing human rights, transparency, accountability, and risk management. UNESCO's Recommendation on AI ethics positions human rights and dignity as central, applying across the AI lifecycle. ⁴¹ NIST's AI Risk Management Framework is explicitly "rights-preserving" and offers a practical structure for managing AI risks across contexts. ⁴² The EU AI Act's risk-based regulatory model and phased implementation represent another institutional mechanism linking AI development to fundamental-rights protections. ⁴³ OECD's AI Recommendation likewise frames trustworthy AI as compatible with human rights and democratic values. ⁴⁴

The third safeguard is **education for leisure**: Aristotle warns that states can fail because they do not educate citizens for leisure, and he treats leisure-virtues as essential. ⁹ A revived scholē politics must therefore fund broad liberal and civic education, so "free time" does not default into manipulation-by-content or addictive consumption.

Comparative table: ancient positions, modern reinterpretations, and AI-enabled implementations

Ancient position	Core claim about labor & leisure	Modern reinterpretation (egalitarian)	AI-enabled implementation (illustrative)
Aristotle (<i>Politics</i>)	Citizens should not live as "mechanics" or "merchants"; leisure is required for virtue and politics. ⁴⁵	No occupation disqualifies citizenship; instead, time-poverty is the civic problem. Aim: guarantee everyone sufficient leisure-capability.	Shorter workweeks + AI augmentation; "automation dividend" distributed as time and income; public investment in civic education for leisure. ⁴⁶

Ancient position	Core claim about labor & leisure	Modern reinterpretation (egalitarian)	AI-enabled implementation (illustrative)
Aristotle (<i>Politics</i> , slavery & automation)	Slaves are “living tools”; if tools worked automatically, masters would not need slaves. ¹¹	Replace “living tools” with non-sentient tools ; absolute ban on treating humans as property or instruments.	Robotics in hazardous/ repetitive tasks; AI agents for routine clerical workflows, with strict labor/ rights standards for human-in-the-loop work. ⁴⁷
Plato (<i>Republic</i>)	Justice requires specialization; guardians must be freed from other crafts and supported by others. ⁴⁸	Keep the insight that governance/truth-seeking requires time and insulation from petty incentives, but democratize it: everyone gets “guardian-like” time for learning and civic engagement.	Civic “learning accounts,” public AI tutors, deliberative platforms; ethics training for AI-assisted governance. ⁴⁹
Xenophon (<i>Oeconomicus</i>)	“Base mechanic arts” degrade bodies and leave no leisure for friendship and the state. ⁸	Target the degrading/ health-damaging aspects of work, not craft itself; protect time for civic and relational life.	Automate injury-prone repetitive tasks; enforce workplace protections for remaining labor; treat AI supply-chain work as dignified employment with enforceable standards. ⁵⁰

Policy and practical implications

A modern scholē project is not achieved by telling people to “contemplate more.” It requires redesigning labor markets, AI governance, and education so that free time becomes a stable social capability rather than a luxury good.

A workable package has five interconnected parts.

First, **capture and share the automation surplus**. Economic research emphasizes that automation’s labor effects depend on task allocation and institutions; without redistribution, automation can concentrate gains. ²⁸ Mechanisms can include social dividends from AI-driven productivity, profit-sharing, broad-based ownership of capital, or taxation structures that return automation rents to the public (the precise mix is contestable, but the need to align incentives is not). ³⁷

Second, **convert productivity into time**. Aristotle’s formula is not “wealth for leisure” but “business for leisure.” ⁹ Policies that directly reduce work time—shorter standard workweeks, stronger vacation norms, and flexible schedules—translate AI augmentation into lived scholē more reliably than only increasing GDP.

Third, **protect workers through transitions.** The ILO stresses that exposure often means tasks are automated within jobs, reshaping job quality; policy should therefore support reskilling and job redesign rather than assuming full automation. ⁵¹

Fourth, **govern AI to prevent domination and hidden exploitation.** To avoid building a new “servant class,” apply enforceable standards to AI supply chains (data work, moderation, maintenance), consistent with the UNGPs’ value-chain logic. ⁵² Use public-facing governance frameworks—UNESCO’s ethics recommendation, NIST’s AI RMF, OECD’s principles, and regulatory regimes like the EU AI Act—as scaffolding for requirements on transparency, accountability, human oversight, and risk management. ⁵³

Fifth, **rebuild education for leisure as civic infrastructure.** Aristotle’s warning about failing to educate for leisure becomes newly relevant in an attention economy. ⁹ A *scholē* revival implies major investment in public libraries, adult education, arts, civic deliberation, and the humanities—institutions that train people to use freedom well, rather than leaving leisure to be colonized by algorithmic engagement systems.

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All of these sources support the central argumentative bridge: **Aristotle's own ideal—leisure as the end of necessary labor—becomes technologically plausible in an AI economy** ⁵⁴, but **morally acceptable only under egalitarian distribution and rights-protecting governance** ⁵⁵.

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